# What the Model Says, and How I Will Grade It

2026 US House and Senate projection · final run frozen 2026-10-29 · published 2026-11-03, before any vote was counted

**MODELLED PROJECTION, PUBLISHED AS A BAND, NOT A POINT · The key parameter cannot be estimated from available data, so it is swept and every row is published. Reading one row without the others is the error this design exists to prevent.**

## The short version

**House:** Democrats favoured under every assumption in the band — P(Democratic control) 0.58 to 0.83. The 90% seat range straddles 218 at every assumption, because 135 of 435 seats sit on newly drawn territory the model has no history for.

**Senate:** leans Democratic, and crosses the coin flip at the most conservative assumption — P(Democratic control) 0.48 to 0.79. A lean, not a call. The seats nearest even at the middle assumption: North Carolina 0.58, Iowa 0.50, Texas 0.49, Maine 0.49, Montana 0.44.

## The prediction, every row

The national environment comes from eight special elections (Apr 2025 – Jun 2026) in which Democratic candidates beat their district's 2024 presidential baseline by 21.2 points of margin on average. Special electorates are not general electorates, so some fraction of that — the *shrinkage* — carries into November. One cycle cannot identify it; four historical cycles do not narrow it. It is swept, not fitted.

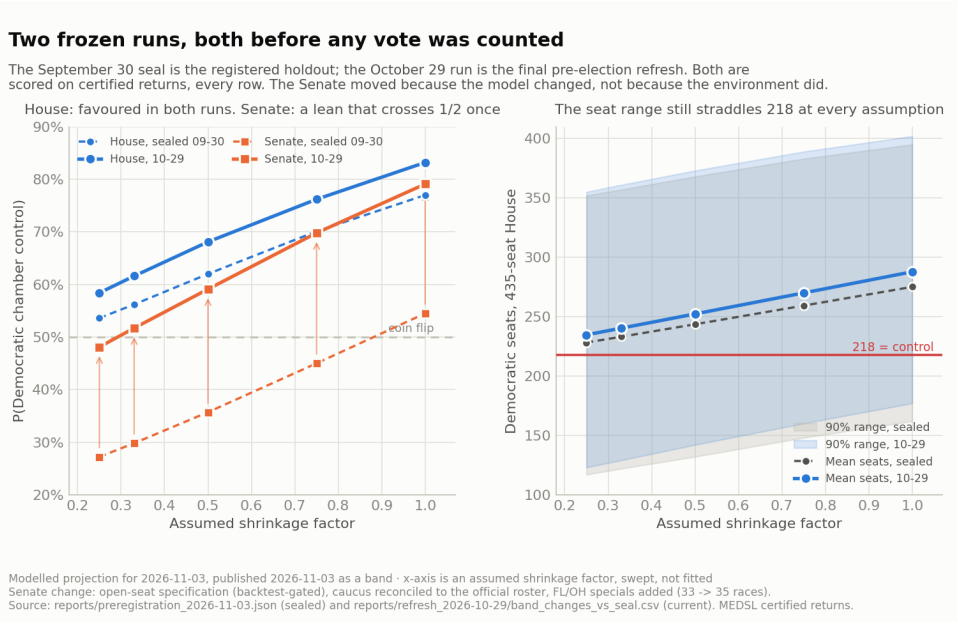
| Shrinkage | Implied nat. Dem share | House mean seats | House 90% range | P(Dem House) | Senate Dem seats /100 | P(Dem Senate) |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 0.25 | 0.524 | 234.7 | 123 – 355 | 0.584 | 51.1 | 0.481 |
| 0.33 | 0.532 | 240.3 | 129 – 361 | 0.616 | 51.7 | 0.517 |
| 0.50 | 0.550 | 252.3 | 142 – 373 | 0.681 | 53.0 | 0.591 |
| 0.75 | 0.577 | 270.0 | 160 – 389 | 0.762 | 55.0 | 0.698 |
| 1.00 | 0.603 | 287.8 | 177 – 402 | 0.832 | 56.9 | 0.791 |

Final pre-election run 2026-10-29 (reports/refresh_2026-10-29/). 2024 House national input, contested races total-vote weighted: 0.497; each row adds a shrinkage multiple of the specials swing. 435 House seats; 35 Senate races up, 34 Democratic and 31 Republican holdovers, 100 seats reconciled to the official roster.

## What the House forecast is standing on

| House seats by prior source | Seats | Sigma | Note |
|---|---|---|---|
| Model (own 2024 result, boundaries unchanged) | 262 | 0.112 | Fitted residual sigma |
| Model, transferred (Texas, precinct vote transfer onto 2026 plan) | 38 | 0.122 | Measured on a 2020→2022 backtest, not assumed |
| Fallback: state presidential lean (redrawn, no transfer yet) | 135 | 0.146 | Least-informed seats; should score visibly worse |
| Total | 435 | | |

Nine states use a different congressional map in 2026 than in 2024 — AL, CA, FL, LA, NC, OH, TN, TX, UT — 173 of 435 seats. Litigation is live in nine of the ten states with map activity (Missouri votes its 2022 map and keeps its priors). The register records the plan in effect as of its last verification; a recheck on 2026-11-03 found no change since.




## Two frozen runs: the September seal beside the October run

A second prediction was sealed on 2026-09-30 (SHA-256 of predictions `4de09ecf82f218ee`…) and is the registered holdout. It is scored beside the October run, by the same rules, never replaced by it — so a reader can judge whether the model drifted toward an answer or toward a better specification.

| Shrinkage | House P(Dem) sealed → Oct 29 | House mean seats sealed → Oct 29 | Senate P(Dem) sealed → Oct 29 | Senate seats sealed → Oct 29 |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| 0.25 | 0.536 → 0.584 | 228.2 → 234.7 | 0.272 → 0.481 | 47.8 → 51.1 |
| 0.33 | 0.562 → 0.616 | 233.1 → 240.3 | 0.298 → 0.517 | 48.3 → 51.7 |
| 0.50 | 0.620 → 0.681 | 243.6 → 252.3 | 0.357 → 0.591 | 49.2 → 53.0 |
| 0.75 | 0.701 → 0.762 | 259.3 → 270.0 | 0.450 → 0.698 | 50.7 → 55.0 |
| 1.00 | 0.770 → 0.832 | 275.1 → 287.8 | 0.545 → 0.791 | 52.1 → 56.9 |

Source: reports/refresh_2026-10-29/band_changes_vs_seal.csv.

### Why the House moved a little

+6 to +13 mean seats. About 4.6 at every row from restoring New York's 26 districts, which an over-strict validator had quarantined (findings F-2, F-3); the rest from a refreshed specials baseline that raised the measured swing from 18.8 to 21.2 points.

### Why the Senate moved a lot — and why none of it is new evidence about the environment

**1. An open-seat term.** The September specification credited every seat with its incumbent's advantage, including seats the incumbent is leaving. A specification that treats an open seat as held by its party, without the personal incumbency term, was promoted by a chronological backtest over 661 held-out Senate races (230 open): MAE 0.0645 → 0.0638, open-seat MAE 0.0663 → 0.0638, 90% coverage 0.935 → 0.944. Seven Republican-held open seats (AL, IA, KY, MT, NC, TX, WY) moved 13–17 points toward the Democratic candidate; four Democratic-held open seats (IL, MI, MN, NH) moved 5–7 points the other way.

**2. The party crosswalk reconciles.** The seal derived party from certified returns and came up two seats short of the actual Democratic caucus. The October run uses the official roster: 34 Democratic holdovers, 47-seat caucus, 100 seats accounted for.

**3. Two more races.** The Florida and Ohio special Senate elections join the universe: 33 → 35 races. October's Senate is therefore a better-specified model, not a better-informed one; the environment is exactly as unidentified as it was in September.

## Declared weaknesses — before the outcome

A prediction is only as honest as its list of known weaknesses. These are on the record before any vote is counted; a post-mortem that discovers them afterwards proves nothing.

- **135 House seats have no prior on their 2026 boundaries.** They use their state's presidential lean (sigma 0.146 vs modelled 0.112). Expect visibly worse per-seat scores here.
- **Renomination is assumed for 267 of 470 seats.** Candidacy was verified from official general-election ballots for 203 seats; 52 seats are recorded as not contested by the sitting member; the remainder assume the sitting member is on the ballot.
- **The national environment is unidentified.** Shrinkage is an assumption swept over, not an estimate; no historical calibration exists.
- **The correlated-error split** (45% national / 25% regional / 30% state) is asserted, not estimated from residuals. Chamber-level interval width depends on it.
- **Litigation is live** in AL, CA, FL, LA, MO, NC, TN, TX, UT. A late court order would invalidate the affected seats' boundaries.
- **Specials are a non-random sample** of seats with a non-general electorate; overperformance is an association with the environment, not a measurement of it, and the swing is measured against presidential baselines and applied to a House basis.

## How this will be graded — rules fixed 2026-09-30, binding on both runs

- **Certified returns only.** Not election-night calls, not unofficial counts. Runoffs and recounts are followed to their conclusion.
- **Every row is scored and reported.** Selecting the best-performing assumption afterwards is forbidden and would void the registration.
- **Per seat:** Brier and log score on win probability; calibration over the backtest's ten bins; MAE on two-party share; 90% and 95% interval coverage.
- **Per chamber:** absolute error on mean seats; whether the realised count fell inside the 90% interval; whether the directional claim held.
- **Split evaluation:** 262 model seats, 38 transferred seats and 135 fallback seats reported separately. A pooled number would hide which part of the chamber the model knows anything about.
- **Comparators fixed in advance:** naive persistence (every seat repeats its 2024 share); the state-lean fallback applied everywhere; the backtest's leave-one-cycle-out House MAE of 0.0787 as in-sample reference.
- **Pre-declared failure condition:** if the realised Democratic seat count falls outside the 90% interval under every row, the model's stated uncertainty was too narrow — a failure of the forecast, reported as one.

## The model's record on past elections (forward-only chronological evaluation)

| Office | Cycles | Model MAE | Naive persistence MAE | 90% interval coverage |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| US House | 15 | 0.065 | 0.080 | 0.913 |
| US Senate (open-seat spec.) | 21 | 0.064 | 0.084 | 0.944 |
| Presidential | 8 | 0.047 | 0.032 | 0.887 |

The presidential baseline does not beat persistence, which is why there is no presidential forecast here and never has been. Source: reports/refresh_2026-10-29/chronological_evaluation.json and senate_specification_gate.json.

## Provenance

| Input | Source | Snapshot / vintage |
|---|---|---|
| Certified federal returns 1976–2024 | MIT Election Data and Science Lab | 2026-09-30 |
| Demographics | U.S. Census Bureau, ACS 5-year | vintage 2023 |
| Geography | Census TIGER/Line, Block Assignment Files; Texas Legislative Council precinct maps | 2022 blocks, 2023/2024 districts; TX PLANC2333 |
| Candidate filings | Federal Election Commission (aggregate use only) | 2026-09-15; refreshed 2026-10-21 |
| Congressional plan register (RD-001) | Official state and court records, verified row by row | 2026-09-30; litigation column researched 2026-10 |
| Special elections | Official state aggregates, per-row sourcing | 11 compiled; 8 used after same-party and double-count gating |
| Senate roster and caucuses | Official roster | 47 D / 53 R, 100 seats reconciled |
| Final run | reports/refresh_2026-10-29/ · git ddc23f4 | frozen in reports/comparison_set_2026-11-03.json (2026-10-29) |
| Registered seal | reports/preregistration_2026-11-03.json · git 9e4e512 | 2026-09-30 · predictions SHA-256 4de09ecf…4100882 |

## What this is not

Not a call on any race. Not a poll average — no polling enters the band; a Texas poll cross-check was run for information only and is scored beside, not blended in. Not a presidential forecast. Not a map-drawing exercise: redistricting is treated as an audit and record-keeping question, and no state is grouped by motive. No individual-level data appears anywhere; every figure is at state, district or race level.

## Attribution

MIT Election Data and Science Lab — certified U.S. federal returns, 1976–2024 (electionlab.mit.edu). U.S. Census Bureau — American Community Survey 5-year estimates (vintage 2023); TIGER/Line Shapefiles; Block Assignment Files (public domain; cited because chain of custody matters). Federal Election Commission — candidate and committee filings; aggregate use only; contributor fields are never used for solicitation, list-building or targeting. Texas Legislative Council — public precinct geography.

## Nonpartisan statement

This project models probability and uncertainty, not a preferred outcome. Close races look close; no probability has been sharpened to carry a storyline. Unofficial results, calls, estimates and certified returns are labelled distinctly and never share a sentence without one. Historical returns are certified; everything else in this document is modelled and labelled as such.

## What happens next

Official releases are captured from election night and labelled unofficial until the authorities certify them. The scorecard — both runs, every row, the split by seat source, and the fixed comparators — is published when enough of each chamber is certified to be evaluable, and not before.

Alex Oswald · Savepoint Analytics · www.alexoswald.ca · Full methodology, code references and the six-post series on the model's design are published on the site.